

WHAT IS ECOLOGICAL REDIRECTION?

English translation of the booklet [O que é o redirecionamento ecológico](#) (design, translation and adaptation: Robin Chiesa and Paul Michalet; review: Polyana Santos). Free translations of cited works; shareable under [CC BY 4.0](#).

To summarize the concept of ecological redirection, we can speak of a process aimed at fitting human activities within planetary limits. It is a recently developed strategic stance, meant to orient action and to reveal its levers. A comparison with the concept of ecological transition can serve as an introduction.

ECOLOGICAL TRANSITION VS. ECOLOGICAL REDIRECTION

Ecological transition	Ecological redirection
The “ecological crisis” is above all a problem of means (energy, consumption, lifestyles, etc.).	The Anthropocene is, above all, a problem of direction . Ends and means are linked.
A horizon of reconciliation is naturally possible, even desirable, between economic development and ecology.	A horizon of compromises is necessary. The first step toward reconciliation is for companies and public institutions to align with planetary boundaries and ecological environments.
Transition leads to optimization engineering .	Redirection leads to the arts and sciences of closure and renunciation .
Transition confuses the “conditions” and the “consequences” of human activities.	Redirection works on the conditions of existence of human activities .
Transition is technically possible without renunciation or closure .	Redirection is technically impossible without renunciation and closure .

Now that we have begun to distinguish ecological redirection from the currently dominant paradigm, the main concepts that articulate this approach can be presented.

HERITAGE

We inherit a set of subjective and concrete entities (companies, institutions and public policies, value chains, supply chains, consumption patterns, production patterns, energy systems, transport infrastructure, and so on) **on which we depend for our short-term subsistence, but which condemn us in the long term**. The reason is simple: these entities are destroying the conditions of habitability of planet Earth. The task is therefore to contest the monopoly of patrimonial continuity, beginning with the mourning of condemned infrastructures — already obsolete from the standpoint of material and extractive sustainability, yet kept alive at great political and economic cost.

Unlike destituent approaches, the problem of heritage is not to suspend apparatuses as a whole, or even civilization itself, but to inherit them — considering that the alternative can drive neither **large-scale action** nor a **truly strategic reflection**, nor can it take **attachments** into account [...] in a dynamic of disattachment–reattachment.¹

ATTACHMENTS AND COLLECTIVE INQUIRY

We are attached to these subjective and concrete entities in every sense of the word “attachment” (emotional, material, professional, and so on), but we cannot simply abandon them. They are there. They structure everyday life and leave marks on the ground — a little more each day. They depend on us as much as we depend on them. Inevitably, we are inheriting these entities and we have to *care* for them.² Attachments can be pictured as the strings of a marionette that would fall to the floor if they were cut brutally, before we had time to learn how to untie them and retie them otherwise. These attachments are revealed by a method inspired by pragmatic sociology:

Collective inquiry is a concept borrowed from the pragmatist philosopher John Dewey, author of a theory of valuation, who argues for a **research programme** to be conducted in common, by everyone, toward a society with a genuinely democratic way of life. It means examining, in terms of their indirect effects, **all formed or inherited attachments** — that heritage of valuations accumulated over time. Valuation is the process by which people, in and through their activities, cumulatively appreciate and/or evaluate **what they hold dear (and what holds them)**, tacitly and explicitly, spontaneously and reflexively.¹

Inquiring into attachments makes it possible to probe “objects” that are hard to access, such as music, religious belief, and the like. It is an inquiry capable of revealing what is not easily visible. The proposal should be taken as an investigation of what is holding individual and institutional trajectories in place (histories, mythologies, and so on), which requires caution when considering *ecological situations*: fabrics of subsistence relationships, dependencies and attachments that condition existence.

Example. In places where droughts are becoming more frequent, residential swimming pools can be expected to be condemned in a relatively short time — even though the culture of having one’s own pool supports thousands of installers, plumbers, gardeners, repairers... A priori it does not look essential from the standpoint of our “essential” needs, yet it is the core of a subsistence system for countless collectives. The strategy of ecological redirection, instead of trying to save these technologies (or promising to turn them into sustainable ones), first proposes to detach the actors caught in these condemned subsistence networks.

Inquiry into attachments (in the broad sense, including dependencies) can be extended by a reflection on “what we are willing to give up,” or “willing to give up in order to keep what is precious to our subsistence.” That is what we propose to call the **ecological redirection protocol**.

CLOSURE AND RENUNCIATIONS

We must learn — and this is the ambition of ecological redirection — to close the things that destroy the habitability of the planet. To that end, ecological redirection seeks to **develop concepts and tools** that will teach us to:

- inherit the things on which we depend but which destroy Earth’s habitability, **describing** the ways we are attached to them;
- determine what we can **keep** and what we must **renounce**;
- carry out, effectively and operationally, renunciations and closures with the help of the arts and sciences of **arbitration**.

This learning must be done **without liquidating democratic and social questions**. The concepts and tools developed by ecological redirection are aimed mainly at **companies** and **public institutions**.

On these premises a “mural of renunciation” was created,³ aimed at a wide public and partly inspired in format by the “Climate Fresk,”⁴ in order to raise awareness of and illustrate the protocols of renunciation originally developed by Origens Media Lab.⁵ The mural organizes a workshop in which groups can discuss and imagine which activities we might give up in order to respect planetary boundaries. By describing the same activity in different ways, participants discover the complexity of the process of renunciation. At the end of the session, they **together elaborate a strategy** to renounce the activity in question, or some of its aspects.

NEGATIVE COMMONS

Negative commons⁶ refer to “negative” “resources,” material or immaterial: waste, nuclear plants, polluted soils, or certain cultural patrimonies (rights inherited from a colonial era, for example from a colonizer, and so on). The great challenge is to *care* for them (or take charge of them) collectively (*commoning*), in the absence of any possibility of starting over from scratch from these realities.

The negative common, in particular, is a matter of valuation (i.e. **giving a negative value to realities often considered positive**) and of collective inquiry. In other words, it requires a “politics of inquiry.”

The question our generation faces is not so much “who is appropriating water or land?” as “what are we going to do with this industrial society that is condemning us to ecological disaster?” Appropriation thus gives way to the question of heritage.

A difficult legacy of ruined realities, sometimes in the sense of *ruina ruinans* (the still-functional remnants of the Globe: organizations, business models, the supply chain, the law of former colonizers, etc.), sometimes in the sense of *ruina ruinata* (polluted soils, eutrophied rivers, but also oil, CO₂ particles in the atmosphere, etc.).¹

Negative commons can lead to the idea of “**communities of non-use**” (*communautés de non-usage*): collectives that seek to stop using certain entities formerly considered “resources” (that qualification having clearly constituted a disinhibition that facilitated and legitimized extractivist approaches).

Example: the Guaíba mine in Porto Alegre (coal).⁷

PROBLEMATIZING COLLECTIVELY

The emphasis on compromises and arbitrations (as opposed to the horizon of reconciliation promoted in ecological transition) can be likened to a form of diplomatic treaty, which fully marks the political dimension of this tool:

Sobriety will be imposed, and with it **its absolute condition: the imperative to reduce inequalities**, forcing us to question the conditions that would make it possible. [...] Detachment from what cannot be maintained must imperatively be **politicized** and become a **collective problem** (in John Dewey’s sense), not confined to an individual perspective — whether small gestures of limited effectiveness, or heroic militant postures showing that a life without smartphones, meat and/or connection to electrical grids is possible. The question will therefore be infrastructural, and must take as a priority **those who cannot demonstrate such “heroism”** (disabled, weakened, vulnerable bodies, etc.).⁸

Moreover, the complexity of the issues and the timescales required by the Paris Agreement can become reasons to give up. Against that observation, the redirectionist approach mobilizes a *coalition design* as a strategy for diversifying levers that will act **at the meso scale** (as opposed to *macro* levels of analysis — development models, societal projects, etc. — and *micro* — individuals); design here being understood as a set of processes or methods, beyond production or ideation.

EXAMPLES OF APPLICATION

Use of the term redirection is a central reference to “direction,” in the fully managerial, administrative and strategic sense of the word. The expression emphasizes that **the Anthropocene requires a change in the very definition of the purposes of production systems that need to be redirected** in terms of economic, industrial and institutional activities. This change of direction, by proposing an integrated approach, contrasts with the sustainable-development model that remains dependent on economic–environmental decoupling.

Within the course Strategy and Design for the Anthropocene,⁹ which trains people in ecological redirection, fieldwork was carried out with actors in a rural region of inland France, to report how this territory anticipates the challenges of coming ecological and social changes, along four axes:

- the “**living territory**” axis focused on everything that would keep this territory habitable in the context of the ecological crisis (global warming, drought, biodiversity loss, etc.);
- the “**circular territory**” axis centred on the revalorization of resources and their circulation, in a context of continuously increasing waste and rarefaction of raw materials;
- the “**social territory**” axis imagined the rurality of the future in its land and social dimensions;
- the “**multiple cosmologies**” axis investigated the plurality of worldviews present in the territory.

This produced four mappings, corresponding to these four axes, included in an inquiry booklet intended for local communities, which could help orient future public policies.

Other work during the course applied design tools and methods — for example the redirection protocol — to the following topics:

- parking infrastructures,
- municipal swimming pools,
- new constructions,

- a textile company,
- a manufacturing industry,
- an airport terminal,
- the institutions of a French metropolis,
- our relations with sharks,
- etc.

THANKS

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